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with other NGOs to avoid duplicating the relief effort. NGOs in the US are using Google Earth to map out areas where bird flu outbreaks have taken place. They claim that with its help, they have been able to contain and sanitise areas where outbreaks were reported.

When Hurricane Katrina hit New Orleans, Google added a Katrina filter to Google Maps to show flood damage, which helped rescue and relief operations. Google Earth is said to have used over 100 map overlays in 24 hours of the hurricane to show the damage Katrina left behind. The reach and effectiveness of an NGO program can have a tremendous impact at the ground level when a tool such as Google Earth is effectively implemented.

Google Earth is now helping NGOs find alternative routes for traffic management at peak hours, saving commuting time and increasing business productivity.

Media houses such as BBC and CNN are using Google Earth to direct TV crews to the spot where the news is unfolding. CNN and *The New York Times* used Google Earth extensively to show places in Iraq when the war was going on and to explain what was happening—this gave viewers a better understanding of the story. Google Earth also showed media houses the topography of regions they otherwise could not access by air or road.

Google Earth is also used by security agencies like US Coastguard and US Army to plan and analyse the security of buildings, VIPs' movements, and the security of institutions. The maps have been helpful both to strategise and remove weak spots from a security cordon.

Reaping The Benefits

Insurance companies have now reduced the number of staff visits to make surveys of buildings or land in the US if they have previous records of the building and if Google Earth images are continuously updated there. In the US, Google Earth images are frequently updated, except for sites of security installations. In most cases where previous records are available, the process of calculating the premium can now be done in couple of hours.

The Flavours Of Google Earth

Google Earth

This basic version is free for download. You can zoom in on any location on earth; the data is constantly being updated, and more and more areas are being covered in more detail. One can use it for entertainment as well as educational purposes. The best part is, it's free!

Google Earth Plus

This is much like the basic version, and is for personal use. The premium features include tracking through GPS waypoints and high-resolution printouts.

Google Earth Pro

This version is for business use, and includes the ability to add polygons of structures on Google Earth images. Additional add-ons include a movie maker, premium printing, and a GIS (Geographical Information Systems) importer.

Google Earth Enterprise

Google Earth Enterprise allows the merging of enterprise data with ASP-based Google Earth data, and publishing this data throughout an organisation. It also has additional tools such as vectors and moving objects fused with Google maps.

Car insurance agencies are saving time by using GPS systems on Google Earth—they can send an agent who is closest to the accident spot, who then points the insurer to the nearest authorised service centre where the claim can be filed. Amica Insurance claims to have reduced the turnaround for a claim from eight days to one!

Media persons or media crew members don't need to know each and every corner of a city to reach a location where news is breaking. This is a good thing, since catching news as it unfolds is a huge advantage.

Rajesh Choudhary, real estate developer at Prestige Group, Pune, says, "We have a new type of customer thanks to this technology. We send our overseas clients images of plots taken from Google Earth, according to the dimensions or preferred location of our clients. After finalising the plot and the price, the client flies down only to sign the final documents. In addition, for customers who are new to the city or locality, it is much easier to make a decision with pin-ups of the locations of railway stations, parks, water bodies, shopping malls, entertainment centres, and so on."

Real-time tracking of their fleet allows transporters to reduce downtimes, manage fleet efficiently, and meet deadlines. If a transporter's truck takes a deviation or wrong path, it can be found in real-time and be corrected before it's too late. A truck can be found even if it is stationary. All this can save thousands of rupees.

Indian Cultivation

Google Earth's low popularity in India is because computer penetration in the SoHo and small business sector is comparatively low, and broadband penetration even lower. Also, the initial cost of Rs 18,400 per year for Google Earth Pro is too much for a SoHo user. But once users understand and maximise its use as a major tool for business, it's just a matter of time before businesses in India, like their counterparts in the US, start using it.

Choudhary adds, "I got my return on investment with my first customer itself. Added to this are the tremendous savings for our company, both in time and money—our agent doesn't have to take the customer to the plot, because the customer already knows it. This saves manpower and travelling time. Hiring surveyors and their men, too, is eliminated, as land can be measured to the last centimetre using Google Earth."

Harvesting It All

Google Earth is a promising and powerful tool, and we will know its usefulness once we start imbibing it in our businesses. Other potential businesses where Google Earth would be used extensively include locating and tapping wind energy, planning agricultural land, and designating relief centres. With the advent of cheaper computers and increasing broadband penetration, we should see Google Earth being a very useful tool in many more businesses. ■

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